

Preface

An economist and a former fashion editor walked into a bar. The finance guru and I were meeting to discuss the state of the property market for this book.

‘It’s a book of hope for first home buyers,’ I told him. ‘Is there any data that shows ... hope?’

The economist thought about it silently – for as long as it took me to have two sips of my drink – and slightly loosened his tie, as if some breathing room might give him an easy answer. In a housing market where median prices are hovering at around \$1 million in our biggest capital cities, he said, first home buyers would have to forfeit life experiences to afford a foot in the door. I walked away from that briefing with the understanding that I should not sugar-(or avocado-) coat this issue.

My hope for this book is that I – now a real estate editor and broadcaster, and a future first home buyer – can give you insider knowledge for the long haul, especially as the property playing field changes month to month, and year to year.

I cannot offer you a silver bullet – governments can’t even do that – but I can help you make better sense of the market, and give you a roadmap from the earliest days of saving to the day you hold your housewarming. This is a first home buyers’ guide for going toe to toe with bank managers, real estate agents and friends at dinner parties – because everyone has an opinion on housing these days. We’ll start with wiping your debt, then look at how to live frugally and save, based on my own tried-and-trusted methods and experts’ insights. We’ll go over the fundamentals of property finance, and how to choose what to buy, and where. Finally, when your bank balance is fat enough, we’ll strategise about how to win the keys.

When I started writing this book, I toyed with the idea of including, as a preface, an interview with one of several prominent, successful Australians who have bought property. Instead, this preface is a promise, from one first home buyer to another.